unexplored territory. The incompleteness and the uncertainty of our knowledge, our precariousness, suspended over the abyss of the immensity of what we don't know, does not render life meaningless: it makes it interesting and precious.

I have written this book to give an account of what for me is the wonder of this adventure. I've written with a particular reader in mind: someone who knows little or nothing about today's physics but is curious to find out what we know, but also what we don't yet understand, about the elementary weave of the world – and where we are searching. And I have written it to try to communicate the breathtaking beauty of the panorama of reality which can be seen from this perspective.

I've also written it for my colleagues, fellow travellers dispersed throughout the world, as well as for the young women and men with a passion for science, eager to set out on this journey for the first time. I've sought to outline the general landscape of the structure of the physical world, as seen by the double lights of relativity and of quantum physics, and to show how they can be combined. This is not only a book of divulgation; it's also one which articulates a point of view, in a field of research where the abstraction of the technical language may sometimes obscure the wide-angle vision. Science is made up of experiments, hypotheses, equations, calculations and long discussions; but these are only tools, like the instruments of musicians. In the end, what matters in music is the music itself, and what matters in science is the understanding of the world which science provides. To understand the significance of the discovery that the Earth turns around the Sun, it is not necessary to follow Copernicus's complicated calculations; to understand the importance of the discovery that all living beings on our planet have the same ancestors, it is not necessary to follow the complex arguments of Darwin's books. Science is about reading the world from a gradually widening point of view.

This book gives an account of the current state of the search for our new image of the world, as I understand it today. It is the reply I would give to a colleague and friend asking me, 'So, what do you think is the true nature of things?', as we walk along the shore, on a long midsummer's evening.